

3.1.2 The politics of the UK

3.1.2.1 Democracy and participation

Key concepts and terminology:

- direct democracy
- representative democracy
- suffrage
- participation
- partisan dealignment.

Focus

Students should develop awareness of development of the suffrage in the UK – debates and issues:

- how suffrage has changed since the Great Reform Act (1832) to the present
- debates regarding gender, class, ethnicity and age
- the significance of the Chartists, Suffragists and Suffragettes
- suffrage as a human right.

Students will be required to analyse and evaluate:

- the nature of democracy
- different types of democracy – direct democracy, representative government
- patterns of participation and different forms of participation.

3.1.2.2 Elections and referendums

Key concepts and terminology:

- majoritarian and proportional electoral systems
- representative democracy
- suffrage
- participation
- voting behaviour
- manifesto
- campaign
- referendums.

Focus

Students will be required to analyse and evaluate the characteristics of different systems used in parliamentary elections and in elections to one of the devolved bodies in the UK including:

- debates and issues around the performance of those systems
- the advantages and disadvantages of those systems
- three key elections since 1945 should be selected for detailed study. These should include:
 - the 1997 general election
 - one election from before 1997
 - one election since 1997.

The study of these elections, the wider political context in which they occurred and the techniques used by political parties in their campaigns will provide perspectives on the issues and outcomes of each election, particularly in relation to the following:

- patterns of voting behaviour/changes over time – as revealed by relevant national data sources, and explanations of how and why they varied in different elections
- the influence of the media on the outcomes
- the reasons for and the impact of party policies on the outcomes
- the reasons for and the influence of manifestos on the outcomes
- the impact of campaigns and leadership on the outcomes
- the role of elections and their influence on policy and policy making
- likely effects of the electoral system on the party system.

These elections should be selected because they exemplify particular characteristics of the British electoral system, electoral behaviour or electoral outcomes eg:

- an election resulting in a landslide victory for one party
- an election where results reveal a clear discrepancy between the number of votes and the number of seats gained
- an election which shows how large numbers of voters are effectively disenfranchised by the preponderance of voters for one party in large areas of the country
- an election the outcome of which is greatly influenced by a particular leadership style or personality

Students should analyse and evaluate the nature and use of referendums in the UK and their impact.

3.1.2.3 Political parties

Key concepts and terminology:

- ideology
- party structure
- party systems
- party funding
- party functions
- minor parties
- political agenda.

Focus

Students should analyse and evaluate:

- the origins, ideas and development of the Conservative, Labour, and Liberal Democrat parties and how these have helped shape their current policies
- party structures and functions of Conservative, Labour and Liberal Democrat parties
- issues and debates around party funding
- relations with, and influence of, the media
- factors affecting electoral outcomes
- policies of minor parties and their impact on political debates and political agenda
- development towards a multi-party system in the UK and its impact on government and policy.

3.1.2.4 Pressure groups

Key concepts and terminology:

- pluralism
- political agenda
- insider and outsider pressure groups
- promotional and interest groups.

Focus

Students should analyse and evaluate:

- pressure groups and democracy – pluralism
- other influences on government and parliament:
 - think tanks
 - lobbyists
 - corporations
 - media
- typologies of pressure groups, including a detailed study of one insider and one outsider group
- methods used by pressure groups
- factors likely to affect the political influence of different groups, such as membership and resources
- links with political parties, government and the media.

3.1.2.5 The European Union

Key concepts and terminology:

- EU institutions

Focus

Students should analyse and evaluate:

- aims of the EU and the extent to which they have been achieved
- the impact of the EU on UK politics and policy making.